Being both autistic and ADHD isn't simply the two lists added together. It's two nervous systems asking for opposite things at the same time.

In plain words

AuDHD describes people who are both autistic and ADHD — very common, and only formally recognised as possible since 2013. Where autism often seeks routine, sameness and depth, ADHD often seeks novelty, stimulation and change. Living with both means constantly negotiating between them.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Craving routine and being bored senseless by it, simultaneously.
- Needing quiet to think, and needing background noise to start.
- Planning obsessively, then abandoning the plan on impulse.
- Deep special interests that rotate without warning and can't be summoned back.
- Looking inconsistent to other people, and feeling inconsistent to yourself.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"They cancel each other out."	They don't. You get both sets of needs, often in direct conflict.
"You can't have both."	You can, and many do. Diagnosing them together was only permitted from 2013.
"They seem fine — organised, even."	The autistic systems can mask the ADHD chaos, at considerable cost.
"Just pick a strategy and stick to it."	Strategies that suit one side often actively wind up the other.
"It's a trendy label."	It's a late correction to decades of people getting only half an explanation.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Structure and spontaneity, available in the same person.

Deep expertise, arrived at unusually fast.

Creative problem-solving with genuine follow-through when interest holds.

Unusual range — comfortable in detail and in the big picture.

Real empathy for people who don't fit tidy categories.

What actually helps

- ☐ Flexible routine, not rigid routine
- ☐ Expect the interest to move — plan for it
- ☐ Rest that doesn't require stillness
- ☐ Several ways to do the same task
- ☐ Reduce demands before adding strategies
- ☐ Forgive the inconsistency, including your own

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"Which bit is loudest today?"

"Would a different way round help?"

"No pressure either way."

LESS HELPFUL

"You're contradicting yourself."

"Pick one."

"But you liked it last week."

Two systems, one person, permanently negotiating. That's not inconsistency — it's arithmetic.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk